

IN CONTEXT

The Gewandhaus

From 1835 to his death, Mendelssohn was musical director of Leipzig's Gewandhaus Orchestra, one of the oldest and most acclaimed in the world. It was founded in 1743 and in 1781 began holding its concerts in part of the Gewandhaus ("garment house"), a building used by cloth merchants, from which it takes its name. A new concert hall, opened in 1884, was destroyed during World War II and the present building, famed for its fine acoustics, opened in 1981. The orchestra also often performs in Leipzig's St. Thomas's Church, which is closely associated with J.S. Bach.



MONUMENT TO MENDELSSOHN OUTSIDE THE
GEWANDHAUS , 1911

Felix Mendelssohn was born into a wealthy, loving, culturally enlightened family that unstintingly fostered his talents. He was handsome and graceful, had a magnetic personality, and was so gifted